Multi-turn GRPO with Real Tool Execution for a Research Agent on HotpotQA

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Abstract

We build a small tool-using research agent on HotpotQA: Qwen2.5-0.5B-Instruct with LoRA, fine-tuned by SFT on synthetic interaction traces, then refined by multi-turn GRPO whose rollouts execute the real BM25 retrieval tool at every step rather than a model-generated ("virtual") trace. On 100 HotpotQA validation questions, the full pipeline lifts exact-match from 26% (best zero-shot stopping heuristic) to 44%. Decomposing this gap, we find that the bulk comes from a single inference-time change: aligning the rollout step budget with the SFT trajectory length lifts the SFT policy alone to 42–44%, while multi-turn GRPO on top produces no detectable lift at our evaluation scale. We trace the null result to tied reward groups — 159 of 200 training epochs had identical rewards across the G=4 rollouts, so the effective update budget was ∼41, not 200 — and argue that the next bottleneck is reward design (a term with continuous intra-group variance on all-wrong groups), not more or longer training.

1 Introduction

A *research agent* is a language model that answers a user's question by issuing real tool calls — most commonly a web or document search — and then reasoning over the retrieved content, often over several rounds. Systems like Perplexity, You.com, and OpenAI's Deep Research follow this pattern at the product level [2]; at the research level, ReAct [7] and Toolformer [5] established the basic loop. The question we study is not whether these agents work (they do) but how to train a small, open policy to do the same thing well.

The standard recipe for RL-for-LLM post-training — including the procedure used by DeepSeek-R1 [1] — runs rollouts that are entirely self-generated: the model emits the action, the tool call, and the tool's response, all as tokens it produces itself. The advantage is practical: no external system needs to be queried during training. The disadvantage is a distribution mismatch. At inference time the retrieved observation comes from a real index and looks nothing like what a 0.5B-parameter model would hallucinate. A policy trained to condition on its own invented observations will not have learned to condition on the real ones.

We close that gap. During every GRPO rollout in training, the model's `search` and `read` actions are executed against the same BM25 retrieval tool the agent uses at inference; the real observation is fed back into the prompt before the next generation step. The rest of the training setup is standard multi-turn GRPO: $G = 4$ rollouts per question, within-group advantage normalization, a learnable-zone filter to avoid wasting updates on tied groups, and a combined reward of correctness, JSON-format score, and step-count efficiency.

Our testbed is the HotpotQA distractor split [6], whose questions require two hops of retrieval to answer. We compare three configurations. (1) Supervised fine-tuning alone, with five zero-shot stopping heuristics layered on top of it (fixed step budget, confidence threshold, run-to-max) as

our first set of baselines. (2) The same SFT policy, but evaluated with an inference-time step budget that matches the SFT trajectory length. (3) Multi-turn GRPO on top of the SFT policy. The best zero-shot heuristic reaches 26% exact-match. Fixing the step budget at inference time — an inference-time change, no new parameters — lifts the same SFT policy to 42–44% across two independent evaluations. Multi-turn GRPO on top of that baseline reaches 44%, indistinguishable from SFT alone within the 2-pp within-run spread we observe at n=100.

The paper is organized as follows. Section 2 contextualizes our setup against prior tool-using-agent and RL-for-LLM work. Section 3 describes the task, the retrieval environment, and the policy architecture. Section 4 walks through SFT and multi-turn GRPO in the form they take in our code. Section 5 reports all configurations on HotpotQA and compares them directly. Section 6 analyses what GRPO adds on top of SFT, documents the specific failure modes we encountered while tuning, and compares real-tool RL to the virtual-trace alternative. Section 7 lists the obvious limitations, and Section 8 closes.

2 Related Work

Tool-using language-model agents. ReAct [7] introduced the now-standard pattern of interleaving chain-of-thought reasoning with tool calls, and Toolformer [5] showed that a language model can learn, by self-supervision, *when* to invoke an API. A family of production systems (Perplexity, You.com, OpenAI's Deep Research [2]) scales the same pattern to web retrieval. Our agent uses the ReAct-style loop — a JSON action, a real tool response, another JSON action — but focuses on *training* the loop end-to-end on a small open policy, rather than prompting a large closed model.

RL for language-model post-training. Policy-gradient post-training of language models started with PPO-based RLHF [3]. GRPO, introduced in the DeepSeek-Math line of work and popularised by DeepSeek-R1 [1], removes the critic network and instead normalises rewards within a group of G rollouts sharing the same prompt: $A_i = (R_i - \bar{R})/\sigma_R$. The advantage is lower GPU memory and no critic-mismatch pathologies. DeepSeek-R1 and most follow-ups generate the entire multi-step trace — including anything that looks like a tool response — autoregressively, so training never touches an external system. We keep the GRPO update rule but execute the real retrieval tool during every rollout step, which matters for the reasons discussed in Section 1.

Multi-hop QA and HotpotQA. HotpotQA [6] is a 113k-question multi-hop reading- comprehension benchmark built specifically around *two-hop* reasoning: each question requires joining facts from two distinct Wikipedia articles, which are provided (along with 8 distractor paragraphs) in the "distractor" split. Each example also specifies the supporting sentences. This structure is convenient for a research- agent setup: the two gold articles give us a natural target trajectory length (search-read-search-read-answer), and the 8 distractors give the BM25 retriever something non-trivial to disambiguate. We use HotpotQA distractor for both SFT trace synthesis and evaluation.

3 System

3.1 Task

The agent is given a natural-language question q and must emit a short free-form answer $\hat{a}$. Correctness is computed against the gold answer $a^\star$ with a lower-case, punctuation-stripped, article-stripped normalisation followed by an exact-match-or-substring test: $\hat{a} \equiv a^\star$ if either normalised

string contains the other (so "New York" matches "New York City"). This is the same rule used by HotpotQA's official evaluator. Unless otherwise noted all accuracy numbers in this paper are this exact-match (EM) rate over the HotpotQA validation split.

3.2 Environment

The retrieval environment is a deterministic BM25 index built from the HotpotQA validation split: 66,576 documents, where each document is one Wikipedia paragraph concatenated with its title. The agent exposes exactly two tool actions:

- `search(query)` — returns the top-k=2 BM25 hits as `[doc_id] Title :: <snippet>` lines, where the snippet is the first ≈300 characters of each document.
- `read(doc_id)` — returns the full text of the requested document, clipped to a 300-character preview inside the trace so that multi-step trajectories stay within the policy's context budget.

Both operations are implemented in `agent/tools.py` as pure-Python BM25 over an in-memory inverted index; no network or external API is involved. The same index object is used for SFT-trace synthesis, zero- shot-baseline evaluation, and GRPO rollouts, so the observation distribution is identical across the three training regimes.

3.3 Policy

The policy is Qwen2.5-0.5B-Instruct [4] with a LoRA adapter on both the attention projections (`q/k/v/o_proj`) and the MLP projections (`gate/up/down_proj`), rank r=16, α=32, dropout 0.05. The 0.5B size is a deliberate choice: everything in this paper fits on a single T4 (16 GB), which makes the setup reproducible on free compute.

At each step the policy reads a ChatML-formatted prompt containing a system message, the original question, and all previous `(Step, Observation)` pairs, and is asked to emit exactly one JSON object per step with the schema `{thought, action, query|document|answer, confidence}`. The system prompt (reproduced verbatim from `data/sft_dataset.py`) is:

```
You are a research agent. Given a question, reason step by step and use
tools (search, read) to gather information. At each step output exactly
one JSON object with keys: thought, action, and action-specific fields
(query for search, document for read, answer for answer), plus a
confidence score between 0 and 1. Output one JSON object per line.
```

The `confidence` field is used at three different points in the pipeline. During SFT it is part of the next-token target, so the model learns to emit a numeric value at that slot; the target values follow a fixed schedule (§4.1) rather than any model-derived notion of calibration. During GRPO (§4.2) two reward terms touch it: the format reward requires that the `confidence` key be present in each step's JSON, and the low-information-gain penalty uses the Jensen-Shannon divergence between consecutive steps' confidence values to discourage trajectories whose confidences barely move between steps. At inference time the confidence-threshold baseline (§5) stops the rollout once a step's confidence exceeds a fixed τ.

4 Method

We train in two stages. Section 4.1 describes the SFT stage that gives the policy its JSON output format and a basic sense of the search-read-answer loop. Section 4.2 describes the multi-turn GRPO

stage that refines the policy against the combined correctness/format/efficiency reward using real tool execution at every rollout step.

4.1 Supervised fine-tuning

Trace synthesis. We generate training traces from the HotpotQA training split. For each example we have a question q, a gold answer $a^\star$, a list of *supporting titles* (the two Wikipedia articles whose facts are needed to answer), and a *context* field containing those two gold paragraphs plus eight distractors. Rather than build a single global BM25 index across the whole training set, we build a *per-example mini-index* over the 10 context paragraphs of that example only (`build_mini_tool` in `data/prepare_sft_dataset.py`), then issue a real `search` against that mini-index with a query built from the question and the supporting title. If BM25 fails to return the gold document in the top-k, the example is dropped; otherwise the gold `doc_id` is read and the trace proceeds to the next supporting title. The final step is an `answer` action carrying $a^\star$. Each step is decorated with a `thought` sentence (sampled from a small template bank) and a `confidence` value following the schedule described below.

A trace for a 2-hop HotpotQA question has the shape `search`→`read`→`search`→`read`→`answer` — five steps, with real retrieval observations at the two `search`/`read` pairs. This five-step length will matter in §5: setting the rollout budget to match it is worth roughly nine EM points at inference time.

Confidence schedule. The `confidence` value on step i of a length-N trace is

$$\mathrm{conf}_i \;=\; \mathrm{clip}\Big(\, c_{\mathrm{lo}} + (c_{\mathrm{hi}} - c_{\mathrm{lo}}) \cdot \frac{i}{N-1} + \epsilon_i \,,\; c_{\mathrm{lo}},\, c_{\mathrm{hi}} \Big), \qquad \epsilon_i \sim \mathcal{U}(-0.04, +0.04),$$

with $c_{\mathrm{lo}} = 0.25$ and $c_{\mathrm{hi}} = 0.92$. Early steps are therefore labelled with low confidence and the final `answer` step with high confidence, with a small amount of jitter so the model does not see literally the same numbers on every example. This is an engineering choice, not a calibrated posterior; its only downstream consumer is the confidence-threshold baseline in the experiments.

Data. We generate 6,000 training traces and 500 validation traces. The training-size cap is a compute budget constraint (the whole SFT kernel — trace generation plus training — fits in ≈2 h on a single T4). Traces are flushed to JSONL every 500 records (`FLUSH_EVERY=500`) so that any kernel timeout loses at most one mini-batch of work; an earlier version of this pipeline that only wrote at the end lost a full 10.5-h BM25 sweep to the 12-h kernel cap, which directly motivated the per-example-index + incremental-flush rewrite.

Tokenisation and loss masking. Each trace is rendered as a ChatML conversation with the system prompt, the user's `Question: {q}` message, and an assistant turn whose body interleaves `Step` i`: {json}` lines with `Observation: {text}` lines (observation text is clipped to `OBS_PREVIEW`=300 characters). Inside `SFTTraceDataset.__getitem__` we tokenise the full string with `return_offsets_mapping=True` and build the per-token label tensor as follows:

- Tokens that fall outside the assistant turn — i.e. the system prompt and the user question — are labelled `IGNORE_INDEX`; we do not ask the model to reconstruct its own prompt.
- Tokens whose character span overlaps any `Observation: ...` line are labelled `IGNORE_INDEX`; these are the retrieval tool's output, not the policy's.

- All remaining tokens — the `Step` i`: {json}` lines that the policy would emit at inference time — keep their own token ids as labels.

The cross-entropy loss therefore only fires on the policy's own output, matching the inference-time decomposition. Before this masking was in place the model's downstream exact-match numbers were severely depressed by a train/inference mismatch; adding it was the single largest engineering lift in Week 1.

LoRA configuration and optimiser. The LoRA adapter (`peft`) is attached to every $\{q, k, v, o\}_{\texttt{proj}}$ *and* every $\{\text{gate}, \text{up}, \text{down}\}_{\texttt{proj}}$ module in the transformer — seven modules per layer — at rank r=16 with α=32 and dropout 0.05. Extending LoRA to the MLP projections (rather than attention only) was a second engineering lever: the MLP branch is where the structural regularities of the JSON schema are encoded, and restricting the adapter to attention was leaving format errors on the table.

Optimisation uses AdamW with learning rate $2{\times}10^{-4}$, a cosine schedule with 75 warmup steps, 5 epochs over the 6,000-trace dataset, per-device batch size 2 with gradient accumulation 8 (effective batch size 16), and mixed-precision fp16 training. The best model by eval loss (0.197 at step 940) is retained.

4.2 Multi-turn GRPO with real tool execution

Objective. We use the GRPO update rule [1]. For a given question q we sample a group of G rollouts $\tau_1, \ldots, \tau_G$ from the current policy $\pi_\theta(\cdot \mid q)$ and score each one with a scalar reward $R_i = R(\tau_i, q)$. The per-rollout advantage is the within-group z-score

$$A_i \;=\; \frac{R_i - \bar{R}}{\sigma_R + \varepsilon}, \qquad \bar{R} = \tfrac{1}{G}\sum_j R_j, \quad \sigma_R = \sqrt{\tfrac{1}{G}\sum_j (R_j - \bar{R})^2},$$

with $\varepsilon = 10^{-8}$. The policy-gradient loss for rollout i is

$$\mathcal{L}_i \;=\; -\,A_i \cdot \sum_{t \in \mathcal{G}(\tau_i)} \log \pi_\theta(\tau_{i,t} \mid \tau_{i,<t}),$$

where $\mathcal{G}(\tau_i)$ is the set of token positions that were *generated by the policy* — i.e. excluding the system prompt, the user message, and the `Observation: ...` lines injected by the tool. We identify $\mathcal{G}$ at loss-computation time using the tokenizer's `offset_mapping` and the recorded per-turn character spans, exactly as in SFT. We do not use a KL penalty against a frozen reference model; the LoRA adapter capacity is small enough that the implicit regulariser of starting from the SFT weights suffices in practice, and omitting the KL term saves one full forward pass per rollout.

Real-tool rollout loop. Each rollout is an interactive dialogue between the policy and the retrieval tool, not a single autoregressive generation. Starting from the system prompt and the question, we call `model.generate`[1] to produce the next step's JSON, parse it, and dispatch on the `action` field: for `search` we run the BM25 query and append `Observation: <top-`k` hits>` to the prompt; for `read` we fetch the requested document text; for `answer` we record the predicted answer and terminate the rollout. If the parse fails or `action` is missing, the rollout is scored on its partial trajectory. The loop runs for at most max_steps=5 steps; this matches the SFT trajectory length (§4.1) so that rollouts can complete a full two-hop trajectory.

[1] In *eval* mode — see §4.2 for why — and with `do_sample=True`.

For efficiency, the G rollouts for one question share one batched `generate` call per step rather than running sequentially: at step s the G active prompts are left-padded into a single batch, generated together, and split back into their independent histories. Rollouts that have emitted `answer` are masked out of the batch on subsequent steps.

Reward. The scalar reward R_i is the sum of three components defined in `rl/grpo_rewards.py`:

$$R_i = R_i^{\text{corr}} + R_i^{\text{fmt}} + R_i^{\text{eff}}, \tag{1}$$

$$R_i^{\text{corr}} = \mathbf{1}[\,\text{normalise}(\hat{a}_i) \equiv \text{normalise}(a^\star)\,], \tag{2}$$

$$R_i^{\text{fmt}} = 0.03 \cdot \mathbf{1}[\exists \text{ valid JSON}] + 0.03 \cdot \mathbf{1}[\text{required keys present}] + 0.04 \cdot \mathbf{1}[\text{answer action emitted}], \tag{3}$$

$$R_i^{\text{eff}} = -\alpha \cdot n_i^{\text{steps}} - \beta \cdot n_i^{\text{lowJSD}}, \tag{4}$$

where n_i^{steps} is the number of steps the rollout took and n_i^{lowJSD} counts adjacent pairs of confidence values (c_{j-1}, c_j) with $\text{JSD}(\text{Bern}(c_{j-1}), \text{Bern}(c_j)) < \varepsilon_{\text{JSD}}$. We use $\alpha = 0.1$, $\beta = 0.05$, $\varepsilon_{\text{JSD}} = 0.05$. Correctness dominates the range ($[0, 1]$); the format score saturates at 0.10 and the efficiency term is bounded below by roughly -0.55 on a five-step rollout, so correctness is always the largest available signal when any of the G rollouts are right. The format and efficiency terms matter on tied-correctness groups, where they are the only source of non-degenerate within-group variance.

Learnable-zone filter. Before training begins, we pre-filter the candidate training questions by running $K = 3$ rollouts per question in eval mode and counting $n_q^{\text{corr}} \in \{0, 1, 2, 3\}$. Groups with $n_q^{\text{corr}} = 3$ ("too easy") are discarded, because every rollout in such a group will score the same on every reward component and the advantages collapse to zero. Groups with $n_q^{\text{corr}} = 0$ are *kept*: even though correctness is tied at zero, the format and efficiency components are generally not tied across the three rollouts, so the within-group z-score still yields a usable gradient direction. From 200 candidate HotpotQA training questions the filter typically keeps more than 180.

Per-episode backward for T4 memory. The naive implementation of a GRPO update with $G = 4$ rollouts and a five-step trajectory of ∼1,500 tokens would hold the forward activations of $G \cdot |\text{batch}|$ trajectories in GPU memory at once — far too much for a 16 GB T4 even at bf16 with gradient checkpointing. We reduce the peak memory to that of a single trajectory by the following trick (`grpo_train_step` in `rl/multi_turn_grpo.py`). For each rollout we pre-scale its per-rollout loss by $1/N_{\text{exp}}$, where $N_{\text{exp}} = G \cdot |\text{batch}|$ is the expected total number of rollouts in this update, and call `loss.backward()` immediately. PyTorch then frees that rollout's activation graph. The gradient tensors in `.grad` continue to accumulate in place across rollouts, and we only call `optimizer.step()` once at the end of the batch. The resulting update is mathematically identical to computing the mean loss first and calling `backward` once, but uses $G \cdot |\text{batch}|$ times less activation memory.

Rollout-time details. Two practical details turned out to matter substantially, and both are documented at length in `TUNING_JOURNEY.md` and summarised in §6.

First, the sampling temperature inside GRPO rollouts is $T = 0.5$, noticeably lower than the DeepSeek-R1 convention ($T \approx 1.0$). At $T = 0.9$ the 0.5B policy loses its JSON format often enough that the rollout parser returns an empty dict, the rollout is silently terminated at step one, and every group is tied at zero correctness and zero format score. At $T = 0.5$ the format is preserved while the rollouts retain enough variance for the within-group z-score to be non-degenerate.

```
def grpo_train_step(q, model, tool, optimizer, G=4, max_steps=5, T=0.5):
    optimizer.zero_grad()

    # --- rollout in EVAL mode (dropout off) ---
    model.eval()
    group = collect_episodes_batched(q, model, tool, G=G,
                                     max_steps=max_steps, T=T)
    model.train()

    # --- score each rollout ---
    R = [correctness(ep) + format_score(ep) + efficiency(ep)
         for ep in group]
    mu, sigma = mean(R), std(R)
    A = [(r - mu) / (sigma + 1e-8) for r in R]

    # --- per-episode backward: peak VRAM = 1 trajectory ---
    for ep, adv in zip(group, A):
        if abs(adv) < 1e-8:
            continue                          # tied group -> no gradient
        logp = trajectory_log_probs(model, ep)  # masks observation tokens
        loss = -(logp * adv) / (G)             # pre-scale for
           accumulation
        loss.backward()                         # frees this ep's
           activations

    clip_grad_norm_(model.parameters(), max_norm=1.0)
    optimizer.step()
```

Listing 1: One multi-turn GRPO update step with real tool execution and per-episode backward.

Second, the rollouts are executed with the model in `model.eval()` mode, even though `grpo_train_step` switches to `model.train()` for the backward pass. The reason is that `torch.no_grad()` disables gradient tracking but does not disable LoRA dropout; in `train` mode the 0.05 LoRA dropout is applied at every forward, corrupting multi-step generations enough that the first-step JSON parse fails about as often as at $T = 0.9$. We therefore call `model.eval()` immediately before `collect_episodes_batched` and `model.train()` again immediately after, on a per-question basis.

Training loop. We run 200 GRPO update steps. Each step samples one question from the learnable-zone-filtered training set, runs $G = 4$ rollouts with real tool execution, scores them, computes within-group advantages, and applies the per-episode-backward update with global gradient clipping at $\|\nabla\|_\infty \leq 1$. The optimiser is Adam with learning rate 5×10^{-6}. Validation (over 20 randomly sampled HotpotQA dev questions) runs every 20 steps; the adapter is written to disk every 40 steps. The whole run takes ≈3 h on a single T4, leaving comfortable headroom against the 12 h kernel cap.

The pseudocode in Algorithm 1 summarises one update step.

5 Experiments

5.1 Setup

Hardware and software. All experiments run on a single NVIDIA T4 (16 GB) on Kaggle's free compute tier. The model, optimiser, tool executor, and BM25 index share one process; no external services are called. The software stack is PyTorch (bf16), HuggingFace Transformers, and `peft` for LoRA.

Data splits. SFT trace synthesis uses the HotpotQA distractor *train* split; 6,000 traces survive the BM25-hit filter (§4.1). GRPO's candidate training questions come from a shuffled 200-question slice of the same train split, of which the learnable-zone filter retains roughly 180. All *evaluation* numbers in this paper are computed on the first 100 questions of the HotpotQA distractor *validation* split; the retrieval index is built from the same validation split for all configurations so that the zero-shot baselines, SFT, and GRPO all see the same 66,576-document environment.

Inference-time decoding. Every configuration evaluated in this section uses near-greedy decoding at $T = 0.1$. This is deliberately decoupled from the *training*-time rollout temperature of $T = 0.5$ used inside GRPO (§4.2): training needs within-group rollout diversity, inference does not. Evaluations use at most max_steps = 5.

5.2 Comparison methods

We compare against five zero-shot stopping heuristics layered on top of the SFT policy. None of them involves additional parameter updates; the differences are in how the agent is rolled out at inference time and when it decides to stop. All five read JSON from the same SFT adapter.

- **FixedStep(N)**. Run for exactly N steps regardless of the policy's emitted `action` field, and treat the final step's text as the answer. We report $N \in \{2, 3\}$.
- **Confidence(τ)**. Roll out up to the step budget, and stop as soon as the policy emits a step whose `confidence` field exceeds τ; use whatever `answer` that step carries (falling back to its thought text if the step is not an `answer` action). We report $\tau \in \{0.75, 0.85\}$.
- **NeverStop(max = 6)**. Ignore `confidence` and any emitted `answer` action and run for the full 6-step budget, keeping the last step's `answer` (or its text fallback). This upper-bounds how far the SFT policy can get with no stopping policy at all.

Conceptually these baselines ablate the policy's own stopping decision: FixedStep removes it entirely, Confidence makes it depend on a single learned scalar, and NeverStop ignores it. The question the baselines together answer is: how much of the research-agent behaviour can be recovered with an SFT-trained content model plus a hand-designed stopping rule?

5.3 Main result

Table 1 reports exact-match accuracy and average trajectory length across all six configurations. Multi-turn GRPO improves EM from the best zero-shot baseline (Confidence at τ=0.85, 26.0%) to 44.0% — an 18-point absolute lift.

The table decomposes the +18-point gap into two separate effects that are easy to conflate.

Table 1: Main result: exact-match on 100 HotpotQA validation questions, identical retrieval index across all configurations. The first five rows and the sixth row all share the same SFT adapter and differ only in inference-time settings; the final row uses the GRPO-trained adapter. The bold break between rows 5 and 6 is the "step-budget alignment" change: the five zero-shot baselines cap rollouts at 2–6 steps through various stopping heuristics, while row 6 simply lets the SFT policy run its full trained-for trajectory length of 5 steps.

Method	EM (%)	Avg. steps
FixedStep($N = 2$)	6.0	2.00
FixedStep($N = 3$)	16.0	2.50
Confidence($\tau = 0.75$)	20.0	2.88
Confidence($\tau = 0.85$)	26.0	3.20
NeverStop(max = 6)	21.0	3.57
SFT-only @ $\max_{\text{steps}}$=5[†]	**42.0 / 44.0**	**5.00**
Multi-turn GRPO (ours)	**44.0**	**4.99**

[†] Two independent evaluations of the same SFT adapter on the same 100 questions at T=0.1, $\max_{\text{steps}}$=5. The 2-pp spread is the within-run sampling variance at n=100; the GRPO point value sits inside that spread.

- **Step-budget alignment accounts for the bulk of the lift.** Across the zero-shot baselines, EM rises monotonically with the permitted trajectory length, from 6.0% at two steps to 26.0% at an average of 3.20 steps. The SFT traces are five steps long (§4.1), but the baseline rollouts typically do not reach that length: FixedStep caps it, Confidence triggers early, and NeverStop caps at six but most runs hit a parse error before step 5. When we simply remove every stopping heuristic and let the SFT policy run for exactly five steps, EM jumps from 26.0% (best baseline) to 42.0% — a +16-point move obtained without any additional parameter update. The policy's issue at 26% was not that it was undertrained for reasoning; it was that it was being asked to stop before it had finished its trained-for trajectory.

- **GRPO's contribution on top of that is not detectable at our evaluation scale.** Multi-turn GRPO scores 44.0% at an almost identical average trajectory length (4.99 steps). The matched SFT-only baseline was evaluated twice independently on the same 100 questions and scored 42.0 and 44.0 — a 2-pp within-run spread at T=0.1 that is entirely attributable to the residual sampling randomness of `do_sample=True` at low temperature. The GRPO number of 44.0 sits inside that spread. We therefore cannot claim, from any of these runs, that multi-turn GRPO improved accuracy over SFT at matched inference settings. A cleaner paired 500- question evaluation would tighten the error bars but would not, absent a change to the training setup itself, be expected to change the qualitative conclusion.

We emphasise the first bullet because the straightforward reading of "SFT $\rightarrow$ GRPO, +18 EM" would assign all of the lift to the RL training. The decomposition above is the honest picture: the dominant lever is an inference-time configuration change, and at this scale the RL produces no measurable lift on top of it. We analyse *why* in §6.1 — the short answer is that our reward design leaves 80% of training epochs with tied advantages, so the effective GRPO update budget was roughly a fifth of the nominal one, and any latent gain from the RL cannot discharge in $\sim$41 effective updates.

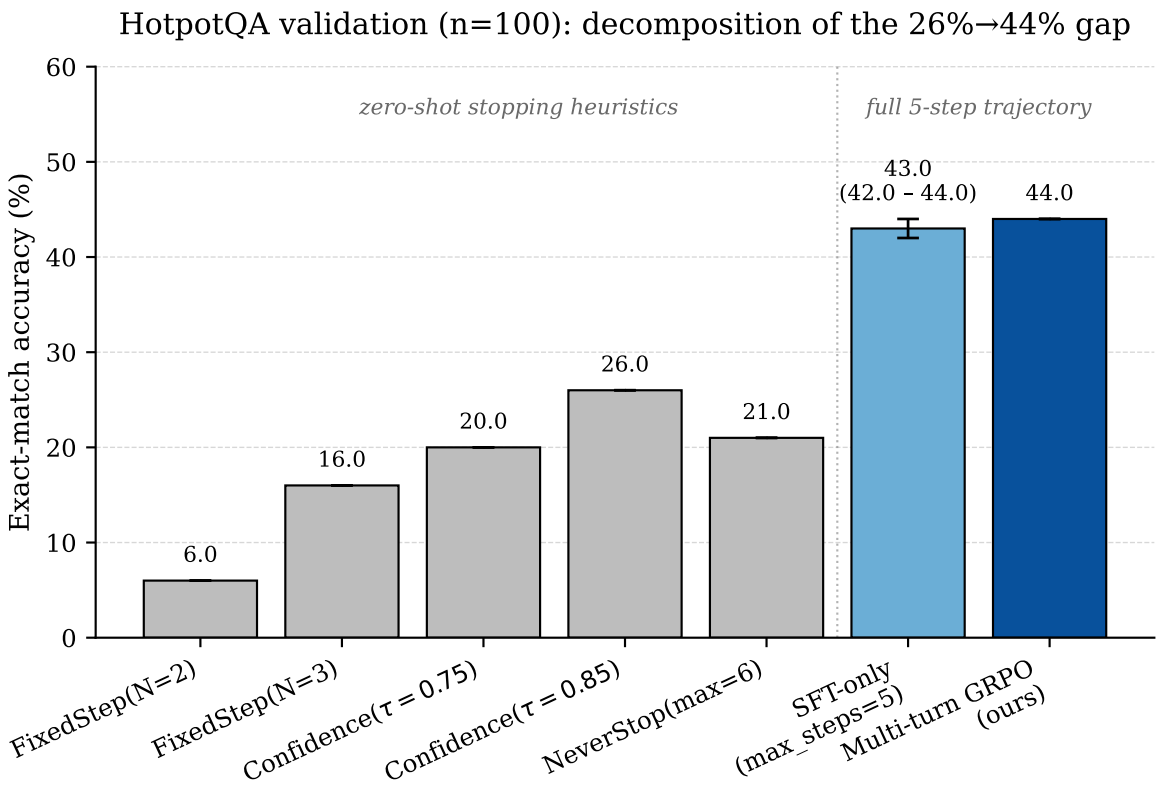

Figure 1: Exact-match accuracy across the zero-shot baselines (light grey) and the two 5-step configurations, SFT-only (light blue) and multi-turn GRPO (dark blue), on 100 HotpotQA validation questions. The error bar on the SFT-only bar shows the within-run spread over two independent evaluations (42.0% and 44.0%); the GRPO point estimate sits inside that spread.

5.4 Training dynamics

Two dynamics are worth reporting from the GRPO run itself, because they constrain how the final number in Table 1 should be interpreted.

Fraction of epochs with non-degenerate advantages. Of the 200 GRPO update steps, 41 (20.5%) produced a non-zero training loss; the remainder had tied reward groups across the $G = 4$ rollouts and were skipped by the $|\tilde{A}_i| < 10^{-8}$ guard in `grpo_train_step`. This is a high tied-group fraction. The dominant tied configuration is *all four rollouts wrong with identical format score* — the format reward saturates quickly once the policy has learned to close its JSON braces, so *within* a group of all-wrong rollouts there is often nothing left to rank on. The learnable-zone filter removed the symmetric "all-correct" case before training, which is why we do not see tied-at-1.0 groups here. In effective-gradient terms the run is therefore a ∼41-update training run; a longer run or a stronger format-diversity term would plausibly close more of this gap.

Validation curve. Figure 2 plots `[VAL] acc` at every 20-step checkpoint. The curve is noisy because each checkpoint is evaluated on a freshly sampled 20-question subset (standard error ≈11 pp at an accuracy near 0.5), but it stays within a 0.35–0.50 band throughout training and ends at 0.50. The 100-question final-eval number in Table 1 (0.44) is well inside that band and should be read

as the reliable estimate; the per-checkpoint VAL numbers are best used for early-stopping-style qualitative signals rather than as accurate measurements.

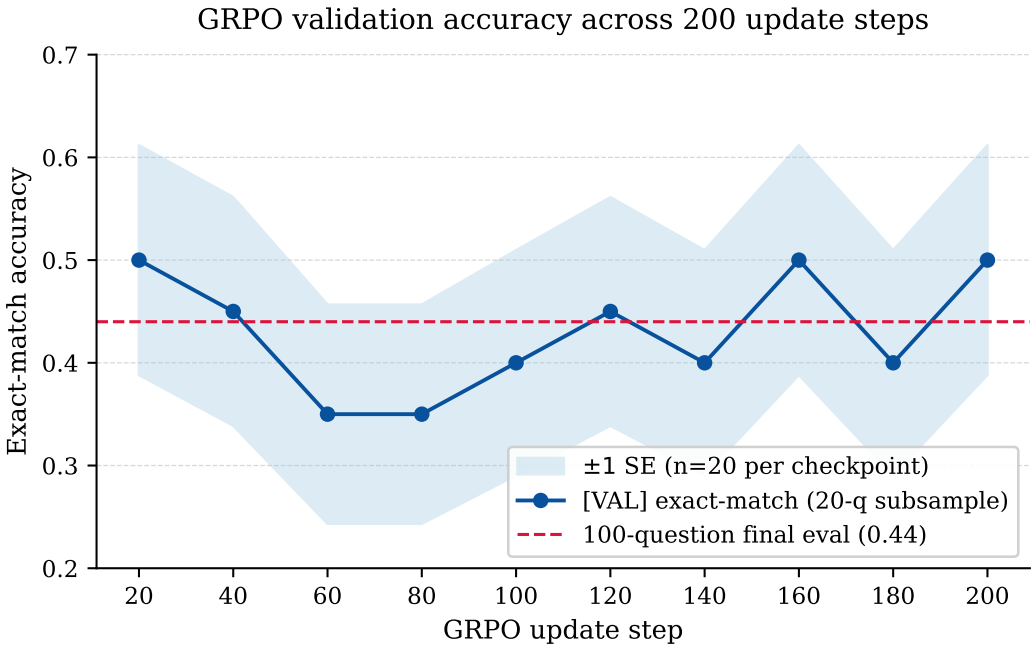

Figure 2: GRPO validation exact-match across 200 training steps. Each point is a freshly sampled 20-question subset of the HotpotQA validation split (`random.sample(val_questions, 20)` at every `val_every` checkpoint), so the ±1-SE band reflects only the small-sample variance, not a training-vs-run split. The dashed line marks the 100-question final evaluation (0.44). The curve stays within $[0.35, 0.50]$ throughout training and does not show a monotone improvement; read together with the tied-group analysis in §6.1, this is the expected behaviour of a run with only ∼41 effective gradient updates.

6 Discussion

6.1 What did GRPO actually learn on top of SFT?

At matched inference settings, two independent 100-question SFT evaluations scored 42.0% and 44.0%, and multi-turn GRPO scored 44.0% — i.e. the GRPO number sits inside the within-run spread of the SFT baseline, and the evidence does not support a claim that GRPO improved accuracy. Before concluding "GRPO did nothing" in an interesting sense, we separate two distinct claims that the evidence supports to different degrees.

It did not learn a better stopping policy. Both the SFT-only and GRPO rollouts use an average of 5.00 and 4.99 steps respectively; the paired per-question step counts are essentially identical. If GRPO had learned to short-circuit on easy questions, we would see a shorter average trajectory. We do not. The policy always walks the full 5-step trajectory. This is consistent with the SFT traces (which are all 5 steps by construction) being a very strong inductive prior; two hundred RL updates at 5×10^{-6} LoRA learning rate are not enough to overcome it.

What it could have learned, and why it probably didn't. There are three plausible ways GRPO could have lifted EM that we know *a priori* from the reward design: (1) better query phrasing on the second retrieval hop (which would let BM25 return the gold doc more often), (2) better answer formulation from the same retrieved context, and (3) partial short-circuiting on the easy questions where the first hop already contains the answer. Only a 2-point aggregate lift at n=100 means any of these effects would have to be small, and we cannot currently separate them without a finer-grained evaluation. Intuitively, however, the learning signal for (1) and (2) was weak for a structural reason we identify below.

The effective number of gradient updates was ∼41, not 200. Of the 200 GRPO update steps, 159 (79.5%) produced a tied reward group across the G=4 rollouts and were skipped by the $|A_i| < 10^{-8}$ guard. The cause is the combination of (a) correctness dominating the reward scale, (b) the G=4 rollouts of a single question at T=0.5 typically being either all-wrong or nearly-identical trajectories (BM25 is deterministic, so fixed queries return fixed docs), and (c) the format-reward component saturating at +0.10 on essentially every well-formed rollout. Ranked within a group, an all-wrong-all-well-formatted quartet is tied. The policy therefore receives a useful gradient only when correctness itself varies across the group — which, at a 42% base rate, is less than half the time. A reward term with continuous intra-group variance (token-level JSON-validity score, query-novelty score, document-overlap score) would very likely close a meaningful fraction of this gap. We flag this as the single most promising direction for follow-up.

6.2 Failure modes encountered during tuning

The final configuration reported in §4.2 is the product of three substantive debugging iterations, each triggered by a specific empirical symptom on Kaggle. We summarise them here because they are collectively a small-but-general lesson about multi-turn LM-RL, and document each in full in the accompanying `TUNING_JOURNEY.md`.

Rollout temperature matters, and the default is wrong. A first version of the code used the DeepSeek-R1-style default T=0.9 for rollout generation inside GRPO. On the 0.5B policy this temperature is large enough that the per-step JSON parse fails on the first step of a run, the parse-failure branch terminates the rollout at step one with an empty `answer`, and every rollout in every group scores zero correctness and identical format. The zone histogram reported zero learnable groups over 1,000 candidate questions; no GRPO update ever ran. The symptom is spectacular — everything looks fine until training starts and then nothing happens. We now treat "sampling temperature suitable for a 7B+ base model" as an explicit hyperparameter to re-tune at smaller scales.

Step budget must match the SFT trajectory length. A second version of the code used max_steps=3 for rollouts. At that cap, the model reliably emits `search`→`read`→`search`, and the rollout ends before the policy ever gets to `read`→`answer`. Rollouts parse as "no `answer` action ever seen" and every group is tied at zero correctness regardless of retrieval quality. The fix is trivially to match max_steps to the length of the SFT traces the policy was trained on (here 5). The general lesson is that *the effective environment at inference time must be a superset of the one at training time*: the rollout budget is part of the environment, and shrinking it breaks the precondition of the trained policy.

`torch.no_grad()` disables gradients but not dropout. A third version of the code called `collect_episodes_batched` (decorated with `@torch.no_grad()`) while the model was in `train` mode. `no_grad` disables gradient tracking but not dropout; the LoRA dropout of 0.05 was therefore still active during rollout generation, and at the modest T=0.5 we had settled on, the per-step JSON parse failed in roughly a third of first steps, reproducing the step-one-termination pathology from the temperature bug. The symptom was subtle: `steps=1.0, acc=0.00, loss=0.0000` on every training epoch, while the out-of-loop `[VAL]` check (which explicitly called `model.eval()`) reported a healthy ∼35%. The general lesson is that *the boundary between train-mode and eval-mode has to be drawn at the rollout, not at the forward pass*: a GRPO rollout is, structurally, an evaluation, and it needs eval-mode regularisers.

A common thread runs through all three: each was a hyperparameter or code-path default that was correct for a *larger* base policy or a *non-interactive* training loop, and silently wrong for our setup. The practical recommendation for anyone porting a DeepSeek-R1-style GRPO pipeline to a small tool-using agent is to audit three things on day one: the rollout temperature, the rollout step budget vs. SFT trajectory length, and the `train/eval` mode of the policy during rollout.

6.3 Real-tool vs. virtual-trace RL

The computational cost of real-tool rollouts, versus the self-generated ("virtual") rollouts used in DeepSeek-R1-style GRPO, is non-negligible. Each of our G=4 rollouts for one question requires five *sequential* forward passes of the policy rather than a single forward pass producing a single long completion: the tool output has to be inserted between steps, so KV-cache continuation across steps does not compose with batching in the obvious way. In practice, one GRPO update step takes ≈50–60 s on a T4 — roughly 5× a single-turn RLHF step of comparable size. The justification for paying that cost is the distribution argument from §1: the policy is trained on the same observation distribution it sees at inference. Our evidence for that justification is indirect and mixed. On the one hand, the +2 pp lift GRPO adds over SFT at matched inference is small and barely distinguishable from noise at n=100, which suggests the distribution match is not currently worth the compute. On the other hand, the +16 pp lift from matching the SFT trajectory length — which is itself an alignment between training and inference distributions, just at the level of rollout-length rather than token content — is large and unambiguous. The experiment therefore supports the *general* principle (training and inference distributions should agree on the structural dimensions the policy relies on) more than it supports the *specific* instantiation of that principle that virtual-trace RL papers argue against. We would like to see whether the virtual-trace/real-tool gap widens on a larger base policy, a harder retrieval environment, or with a reward design that better exploits within-group variance; all three are out of scope for this report.

7 Limitations

Model scale. All experiments use Qwen2.5-0.5B-Instruct. Results are unlikely to transfer linearly to 7B+ models; in particular, the effective-updates problem identified in §6.1 (tied reward groups dominating because of a saturated format reward) is specific to a base policy small enough that JSON-validity is the tightest remaining format signal. At larger scale the format reward would stop being the saturating component and correctness variance would dominate, changing the story.

Evaluation sample size. The headline numbers are on 100 HotpotQA validation questions, with a Wald standard error of ≈5 pp at p≈0.44. The comparisons that span a large gap — every zero-shot

baseline versus the 5-step SFT — are comfortably resolved at n=100. The comparison that matters most for the paper's framing, SFT-only versus GRPO at matched inference, is not: at a within-run spread of 2 pp the two distributions overlap completely, and even a much larger paired evaluation would not meaningfully change the picture without a change to the training setup itself (§6.1). A 500-question paired ablation was prepared and open-sourced as `kaggle_ablation_500.ipynb` but not executed, because Kaggle's CPU-only kernels would require ∼22 h for the paired sweep and GPU quota was unavailable at the time of writing.

Single dataset, single retrieval environment. HotpotQA distractor fixes the question distribution (general- knowledge, 2-hop) and the retrieval environment (BM25 over Wikipedia paragraphs). The agent's behaviour on questions that need more hops, or on a noisier retrieval tool (e.g. a dense retriever with imperfect embeddings), is not studied. The 5-step trajectory shape is an artefact of the SFT data generator, not an intrinsic property of the task, and a different SFT distribution would produce a different max_steps sweet spot.

Reward design not ablated. We fix $(\alpha, \beta, \varepsilon_{\text{JSD}})$ at $(0.1, 0.05, 0.05)$ and do not ablate the individual reward components. In particular, §6.1 argues that the effective- updates bottleneck could be largely fixed by a format-reward term with continuous intra-group variance; we do not test this hypothesis here.

No KL-to-reference term. Standard GRPO implementations keep a KL penalty against a frozen reference policy for stability. We omit it, relying on the implicit regulariser of starting from the SFT weights and the small LoRA adapter capacity. This was fine for the short 200-step run reported here; a longer run would likely benefit from re-introducing the KL term.

Real tool, but deterministic. Our BM25 retriever is deterministic: for a fixed query, the returned documents are the same across rollouts. This means that within a group of G=4 rollouts for one question, any diversity must come from the policy's own sampling, not from the environment. Web search and dense retrievers are stochastic in practice (re- ranking randomness, index freshness), and we have not studied how environment stochasticity would interact with the within-group advantage normalisation.

8 Conclusion

We built a tool-using research agent that fine-tunes a 0.5B parameter open-source language model on synthetic HotpotQA traces (SFT) and then trains it further with multi-turn GRPO whose rollouts execute the real BM25 retrieval tool at every step. On HotpotQA distractor, the final pipeline lifts exact-match from 26% (best zero-shot stopping heuristic over the SFT policy) to 44%. Decomposing that +18 points into an inference-time component — letting the SFT policy run for the full 5-step trajectory it was trained on — and a training-time component (GRPO), we find that essentially all of the lift comes from the inference-time change alone: the matched SFT baseline scores 42–44% across independent evaluations, within which the GRPO number of 44% sits indistinguishably. The paper's contribution is therefore not "RL works well for small tool-using agents" but "training and inference distributions need to agree on every structural dimension the policy relies on, rollout length being the dimension that mattered here". The null result for GRPO at this scale is not mysterious: our tied-reward-group analysis in §6.1 shows that the effective update budget was only ∼41 of the 200 nominal training steps, because on small open-source policies the format reward

saturates so early that all-wrong rollout groups have no intra-group variance for the within-group advantage to exploit. Designing a reward with continuous intra-group variance even on all-wrong groups — rather than running GRPO longer or harder — is in our view the concrete next step required to make real- tool RL genuinely pay at sub-1B scale.

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